Share Inspiring User Stories

One way to make sense of your empathic research data is to **share the most inspiring user stories** you've come across with your team. Think about user stories or experiences that have stuck with you: stories that surprised you, made you curious and verified or falsified your assumptions. Please note, it's particularly important to recall and highlight stories which falsify your previous assumptions—you don't want to move forward in the design thinking process with your own wishes in mind. You need to pay real attention to your users' core stories to uncover their needs and ensure the design process remains focused on them at all times.

Stories will most likely not provide you with the ultimate solutions to your design challenge, but chances are they'll resonate with, **engage and inspire your team**. At the international design company IDEO, for example, team members share inspiring user stories with each other so they become part of their collective consciousness.

"The goal is to build a repository of stories for your team to draw from, tell, and retell. Capturing those resonant ideas and feelings, and building them into the very narrative of your team's work helps everyone down the line."

– IDEO.org

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How to Construct Your User Story Madlib

You should try to tell the most essential user stories and consider them a series of steps within a broader system of knowledge and insights.

The most effective way to portray your users' stories is through the use of user story madlibs. This requires you to define whom your story is about, what they want to achieve and why. Once you have honed in on these three aspects of your story, you can input them into the following user story madlib:

As a **[who are they]**, he/she wants to **[what do they want to do]**, so that **[their end goal]**.

Madlib example 1: As a **freelance consultant**, Peter wants to **easily schedule meetings**, so that **he can ensure his schedule is always organized and effective**.

Madlib example 2: As a **corporate web designer**, Lisa wants to **improve the company's website**, so that **users can easily find and get access to what they need**.

As a _____ **,** _____ **wants to** _____
[the user's role] [the user] [user's need]

so that _____ **.**
[the user's end goal]

Steps for the Facilitator

01: Tell your most compelling user stories from the Empathize phase to your team. You should be both specific (what actually happened) and descriptive (use your physical senses to give texture to your description). Report on who, what, when, where, why and how.

02: Invite each of your team-mates to share their own inspiring user stories in a similar way.

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03: As you and your team listen to each other's stories, you should all write down notes and observations on Post-its. You should use concise and complete sentences that everyone on your team can easily understand. Write down quotes, household details, income, aspirations, barriers, the person's life history and any other relevant observations.

04: Make sure to write large enough so that everyone can read your notes. Then gather all the Post-its up on the wall, organize them into separate categories to represent each user your team interviewed and each place your team visited. At the end of your story-sharing session, you'll have many sheets lined up on the wall with hundreds of Post-it notes.

How to Use Your Inspiring User Stories

Your team can use these user stories:

- When you start to define the problem statement (also known as the design challenge or Point of View).
- For solid inspiration when you create personas.
- As a collective consciousness when you start to ideate and imagine design opportunities and solutions.

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Get ready to unpack, explore and master design thinking—using it to set yourself apart and unlock the next stage of your professional life.

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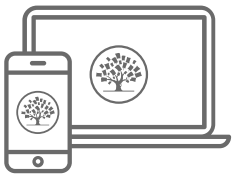

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